

K=colors

1=directions

2=seasons

3=animals (eagle – east, wolf – south, buffalo – west, bear – north)

4=elements

5=stages of life

6=emotions

7=traditional medicine

Lesson Plan: Understanding the Medicine Wheel (K–1)

Grade Level: Kindergarten–Grade 1

Time Needed: 30–45 minutes

Big Ideas (BC Curriculum):

- Stories and traditions help us learn about ourselves, our families, and our communities.
- People connect to others and share who they are through stories and traditions.

First Peoples Principles of Learning:

- Learning is holistic, reflexive, reflective, experiential, and relational.
- Learning involves recognizing the consequences of one's actions.
- Learning involves generational roles and responsibilities.

Learning Objectives:

Students will:

- Learn the four parts of the Medicine Wheel (mental, emotional, physical, and spiritual).
- Recognize the circular and color-coded design of the Medicine Wheel.
- Reflect on how each part connects to their own lives.
- Practice respect and curiosity when learning about Indigenous knowledge.

Materials:

- Large poster or digital display of the Medicine Wheel
- Printable blank Medicine Wheel templates
- Crayons/markers in white, yellow, red, and black
- Picture books or short video introducing the Medicine Wheel (e.g., *We All Count: A Book of Cree Numbers*)
- Small talking stick or sharing item (optional for circle time)

Lesson Steps:

1. Welcome Circle (5–10 min)

- Begin with a land acknowledgment.
- Sit in a circle and discuss how we are all connected.
- Introduce the Medicine Wheel as a symbol of balance and well-being.

2. Introduction to the Medicine Wheel (10 min)

- Show the Medicine Wheel image and explain the four parts:
 - **White (North):** Spiritual
 - **Yellow (East):** Mental
 - **Red (South):** Emotional
 - **Black (West):** Physical
- Discuss how all parts are equally important and interconnected.

3. Story or Video (5–10 min)

- Read a story or show a short video about the Medicine Wheel or Indigenous teachings.

4. Hands-On Activity (10–15 min)

- Give students a blank Medicine Wheel worksheet.
- Guide them to color each section with the correct color.
- Ask them to draw something in each section that reflects their life (e.g., what makes them feel happy, strong, calm, or thoughtful).

5. Sharing Circle (5–10 min)

- Invite students to share one part of their wheel.
- Use a talking stick to encourage respectful listening and speaking.

Assessment:

- Check for understanding through completed Medicine Wheel worksheets.

Extensions:

- Use the Medicine Wheel for emotional check-ins.
 - Add songs or drumming activities.
 - Make a class Medicine Wheel that includes everyone's ideas.
-

Lesson Plan: Exploring the Medicine Wheel (Grades 2–3)

Grade Level: Grades 2–3

Time Needed: 45–60 minutes

Big Ideas (BC Curriculum):

- Indigenous knowledge is passed down through oral history, traditions, and collective memory.
- Learning about ourselves and others helps us build respectful relationships.
- Stories and traditions connect us to the past and help us understand our place in the world.

First Peoples Principles of Learning:

- Learning is holistic, reflexive, reflective, experiential, and relational.
- Learning involves generational roles and responsibilities.
- Learning recognizes the role of Indigenous knowledge systems and worldviews.

Learning Objectives:

Students will:

- Identify and explain the four quadrants of the Medicine Wheel.
- Connect each quadrant to a season (e.g., spring is yellow, and the sun comes up in the east; summer is red, and there are beautiful sunsets and warm weather in the south; in the fall the clocks turn back an hour and it gets dark (black) earlier; winter in the north, lots of white snow).
- Show respect and curiosity when learning from Indigenous teachings.

Materials:

- Poster or projected image of the Medicine Wheel
- Printed Medicine Wheel worksheet (blank and/or labeled)
- Markers, crayons, or colored pencils
- Journals or reflection sheets
- Indigenous storybook or short video (e.g., *The Sacred Tree*, *You Hold Me Up*)

Lesson Steps:

1. Opening Discussion (10 min)

- Begin with a land acknowledgment.
- Ask: "What does it mean to be balanced or to take care of yourself in different ways?"
- Introduce the Medicine Wheel and explain that it is used by many Indigenous communities as a guide for balance and well-being.

2. Teach the Four Quadrants (10–15 min)

- Discuss each part of the wheel:
 - **White (North):** Winter
 - **Yellow (East):** Spring
 - **Red (South):** Summer
 - **Black (West):** Fall
- Ask students what they and their families do during the different seasons.

3. Story Connection (10–15 min)

- Read an Indigenous story or watch a short video to learn more about the Medicine Wheel.
- Prompt students to think about which parts of the Medicine Wheel they noticed in the story.

4. Creative Activity (15–20 min)

- Brainstorm as a class, or in small groups, what they do during the different seasons.
- Students complete a Medicine Wheel worksheet: color each quadrant and write or draw an example of something they do during the different seasons.
-

5. Reflection and Sharing (5–10 min)

- Ask students to write or draw one way they want to work on balance in their lives.~~DELETE~~
- Invite a few students to share their reflections with the class.

Assessment:

- Participation in discussion and sharing
- Completed Medicine Wheel worksheet with personal connections
- Journal or reflection entries showing understanding of concepts covered

Extensions:

- Integrate art by making a large collaborative classroom Medicine Wheel.
-

Lesson Plan: Deepening Understanding of the Medicine Wheel (Grades 4–5)

Grade Level: Grades 4–5

Time Needed: 60–90 minutes

Big Ideas (BC Curriculum):

- Indigenous peoples have rich cultural traditions and perspectives passed down through oral history, traditions, and collective memory.
- Exploring different worldviews helps us develop empathy, respect, and understanding of others.
- Well-being includes physical, mental, emotional, and spiritual aspects.

First Peoples Principles of Learning:

- Learning is holistic, reflexive, reflective, experiential, and relational.
- Learning involves generational roles and responsibilities.
- Learning involves recognizing the consequences of one's actions.
- Learning recognizes Indigenous knowledge systems and worldviews.

Learning Objectives: Students will:

- Explain the symbolism and teachings of the Medicine Wheel.
- Connect each quadrant of the wheel to personal experiences and community well-being.
- Understand the cyclical nature of time and seasons in Indigenous worldviews.
- Engage in respectful discussion of Indigenous knowledge.

Materials:

- Visual of the Medicine Wheel with labeled directions, colors, seasons, and meanings
- Chart paper or whiteboard
- Individual Medicine Wheel worksheet or blank template
- Markers or colored pencils
- Indigenous storybook or video (e.g., *The Circle of Life*, *Shin-chi's Canoe*)
- Reflection journal or writing paper

Lesson Steps:

1. Introduction & Land Acknowledgment (5–10 min)

- Welcome students and acknowledge the traditional territory.
- Ask: "What do you know about Indigenous teachings or ways of understanding the world?"
- Introduce the Medicine Wheel as a holistic model used in many Indigenous cultures.

2. Teaching the Medicine Wheel (15–20 min)

- Show a detailed image of the Medicine Wheel with four quadrants:
 - **White (North - Winter - Spiritual)**
 - **Yellow (East - Spring - Mental)**
 - **Red (South - Summer - Emotional)**
 - **Black (West - Fall - Physical)**
- Discuss how each quadrant relates to life, growth, and balance.
- Help students understand the four parts of wellness in age-appropriate language:
 - **Spiritual:** Feeling connected to the world, nature, and your own sense of purpose. It can include quiet time, gratitude, or feeling peaceful.
 - **Mental:** Using your brain to learn, solve problems, and make decisions. Reading, learning something new, or thinking carefully are ways we grow mentally.
 - **Emotional:** Understanding and expressing your feelings in a healthy way. Talking about emotions, helping others, or calming down when upset shows emotional strength.
 - **Physical:** Taking care of your body by being active, eating well, getting rest, and staying clean. Activities like playing outside or sports support physical health.
- Explain that different Nations may interpret the wheel differently.

3. Story Connection (15–20 min)

- Read or view an Indigenous story that reflects balance, growth, or seasonal cycles.
- Prompt discussion: "Which parts of the Medicine Wheel can we see in this story?"

4. Student Activity (20–30 min)

- Students fill out their own Medicine Wheel worksheet.
- In each quadrant, they draw or write about what helps them grow in that area (e.g., for Physical: playing soccer).
- Option: Have students write a short paragraph about the importance of balance in their life.

5. Reflection & Sharing (10–15 min)

- Invite students to share insights or something new they learned.
- Encourage respectful listening and acknowledgment of different perspectives.

Assessment:

- Participation in discussions and reflections
- Completed worksheet with meaningful connections
- Optional written reflection on balance and well-being

Extensions:

- Research how different Indigenous Nations use the Medicine Wheel.
 - Create a classroom mural or collaborative wheel with shared ideas.
 - Integrate science or health topics (e.g., body systems, emotional regulation) through the lens of the Medicine Wheel.
-

Lesson Plan: Understanding the Medicine Wheel

Grade Level: 6–7

Duration: 1–2 class periods (60–90 mins total)

Big Ideas (BC Curriculum):

- Learning about Indigenous perspectives helps us understand the importance of balance and respect in our lives and communities.
 - Systems and ideas from Indigenous cultures offer holistic approaches to health, identity, and interconnectedness.
-

Learning Objectives

By the end of the lesson, students will:

- Understand the four quadrants of the Medicine Wheel (mental, physical, emotional, spiritual).
 - Explore how the Medicine Wheel is used to support well-being and balance.
 - Reflect on how these teachings relate to their own lives.
 - Respectfully engage with Indigenous worldviews and teachings.
-

Curricular Competencies

- **Social Studies / Core Competencies:**
 - Demonstrate respectful understanding of First Peoples perspectives and knowledge.
 - Connect personal experiences to broader concepts of identity and wellness.
 - **Health & Physical Education:**
 - Identify strategies to support mental, emotional, and social well-being.
-

Materials Needed

- Chart paper or whiteboard
 - Projector or printed visuals of the Medicine Wheel
 - Student handouts (blank and coloured Medicine Wheel templates)
 - Markers or crayons
 - Optional: video or guest speaker from a local Indigenous community
-

Lesson Steps

1. Opening Circle / Introduction (10–15 min)

- Begin with a respectful land acknowledgment.
- Ask: “*What does being healthy mean to you?*” Write student ideas on the board.
- Introduce the Medicine Wheel as a holistic way many Indigenous cultures view health and balance.

2. Explore the Medicine Wheel (15–20 min)

- Show a visual of the Medicine Wheel (with white on top, yellow on right, red on bottom, black on left).
- Discuss the meaning of each quadrant:
 - **White (Spiritual)** – beliefs, connection to something greater
 - **Yellow (Mental)** – thinking, learning
 - **Red (Physical)** – body, activity
 - **Black (Emotional)** – feelings, relationships
- Emphasize that meanings and interpretations can vary by Nation and that this is just one version.

3. Student Reflection Activity (20–30 min)

- Provide students with a blank Medicine Wheel template.
- Ask them to draw or write examples of how they take care of their **body, mind, emotions, and spirit**.
- Share in partners or small groups (optional sharing with class).

4. Wrap-Up Discussion (10 min)

- What did you learn from the Medicine Wheel today?
 - How can this way of thinking help us stay balanced and healthy?
-

Extensions

- Invite an Indigenous Elder or Knowledge Keeper to speak (with appropriate protocols).
 - Create a classroom “Wellness Wheel” mural.
 - Connect with Science or Health units on systems of the body, mental wellness, or emotional regulation.
-

Assessment

- Observation during discussion and sharing
 - Completion and thoughtfulness in Medicine Wheel reflection
 - Optional: Exit slip → *“One thing I learned from the Medicine Wheel is...”*
-
-

Student friendly clarification of spiritual, mental, emotional and physical well-being.

Spiritual clarity is about understanding who we are, how we are connected to the world, and what gives our life meaning. In the Medicine Wheel, the **north side** often represents the **spiritual part** of ourselves. It reminds us that being healthy isn’t just about our body or mind—it also means feeling connected, calm, and balanced inside.

Spiritual clarity can come from spending time in nature, thinking quietly, being thankful, or learning from stories and traditions. It helps us feel strong in who we are and helps guide the choices we make in life. Just like the other parts of the Medicine Wheel—physical, mental, and emotional—the spiritual side is important for living in balance and harmony.

Spiritual clarity is about feeling connected—to yourself, to others, to nature, and to something greater than yourself. In the Medicine Wheel, the **north side** is often connected to the **spiritual part** of who we are. It reminds us to take time to reflect, be thankful, and find meaning in our lives.

Spiritual clarity doesn’t have to be about religion. It can be about feeling peaceful, doing what’s right, or understanding your purpose. Spending quiet time, learning from Elders, listening to stories, or being in nature can all help us feel more spiritually balanced. Just like the emotional, physical, and mental parts of the Medicine Wheel, the spiritual part helps us live a healthy and balanced life.

Mental clarity means having a clear and focused mind. In the Medicine Wheel, the **East side** often represents the **mental part** of ourselves. It reminds us how important it is to think clearly, learn new things, and make good decisions.

Mental clarity helps us solve problems, stay focused in class, and understand the world around us. We can support our mental well-being by getting enough rest, being curious, asking questions, and learning in different ways. Just like the other parts of the Medicine Wheel—emotional, physical, and spiritual—the mental side helps us live a balanced and healthy life.

Physical clarity means taking care of your body and understanding how your actions affect your health and energy. In the Medicine Wheel, the **south side** often represents the **physical part** of who we are. It reminds us that our bodies are important and need movement, rest, and care.

Physical well-being includes things like eating healthy food, staying active, getting enough sleep, and knowing when to take breaks. When we take care of our bodies, we feel stronger, more focused, and ready to enjoy life. Just like the mental, emotional, and spiritual parts of the Medicine Wheel, the physical side helps us live in balance every day.

Emotional clarity means understanding your feelings and how to express them in a healthy way. In the Medicine Wheel, the **west side** is often connected to the **emotional part** of who we are. It reminds us to care for our hearts and relationships.

We feel emotionally clear when we can name our emotions—like happy, sad, angry, or excited—and know how to deal with them without hurting ourselves or others. Talking to someone, writing in a journal, or taking deep breaths can help us feel more balanced. Just like the mental, physical, and spiritual parts of the Medicine Wheel, the emotional side is important for living a healthy and respectful life.

Common Medicine Wheel Totem Animals and Their Meanings

Let's delve into some of the most common totem animals found in the Medicine Wheel, exploring their unique characteristics and symbolic meanings. This deeper understanding will help you interpret your animal's message.

Eagle: Vision and Spiritual Guidance

The Eagle is a powerful **symbol of vision, spiritual guidance, and courage**. Its ability to soar above the clouds represents a connection to the higher realms. This Medicine Wheel Totem Animals Guide will help you understand your Totem Animal.

The eagle's keen eyesight symbolizes clarity and insight. This creature's courage reflects the strength to overcome challenges.

If the eagle appears as your totem, it may be a sign to trust your intuition and embrace your spiritual path with courage and clarity.

Bear: Strength, Healing, and Protection

The Bear is a powerful **symbol of strength, healing, and protection**. It represents the ability to endure hardship and emerge stronger on the other side. It also embodies the protective mother instinct and the wisdom of elders.

Bears are known for their resilience and strength. They represent the capacity to overcome any obstacle.

If the bear is your totem, it may be a sign to trust your inner strength and to seek healing from any wounds or traumas that you may be carrying. The Medicine Wheel Totem Animals Guide will assist you in understanding this.

Wolf: Loyalty, Intuition, and Family

The Wolf is a powerful **symbol of loyalty, intuition, and family**. It represents the importance of community, the strength of family bonds, and the power of intuition. Wolves are known for their pack mentality and their deep connection to family.

Wolves are also known for their keen senses and their ability to navigate challenging terrains. This represents intuition and resilience.

If the wolf is your totem, it may be a sign to trust your intuition, strengthen your family bonds, and seek support from your community. Understanding this requires a deep dive into the Medicine Wheel Totem Animals Guide.

Buffalo: Abundance, Strength, and Community

The Buffalo represents **abundance, strength, and community**. Its powerful presence symbolizes the interconnectedness of life and the importance of collective strength. The buffalo's strength reflects the power of unity.

Buffalo teaches us about the importance of cooperation and mutual support. Abundance is often associated with the buffalo's presence.

If the buffalo is your totem, it may be a reminder to work together, to appreciate abundance, and to connect with your community. Refer to your Medicine Wheel Totem Animals Guide for more insights.

Snake: Transformation, Healing, and Wisdom

The Snake is a powerful symbol of transformation, healing, and wisdom. Its ability to shed its skin represents cycles of renewal and rebirth. Snakes are often associated with mystery and intuitive wisdom.

The snake's healing powers are legendary in many cultures. It symbolizes the ability to overcome challenges.

If the snake is your totem, it may be a sign to embrace change, to trust your intuition, and to seek healing from past traumas. Utilize the Medicine Wheel Totem Animals Guide.

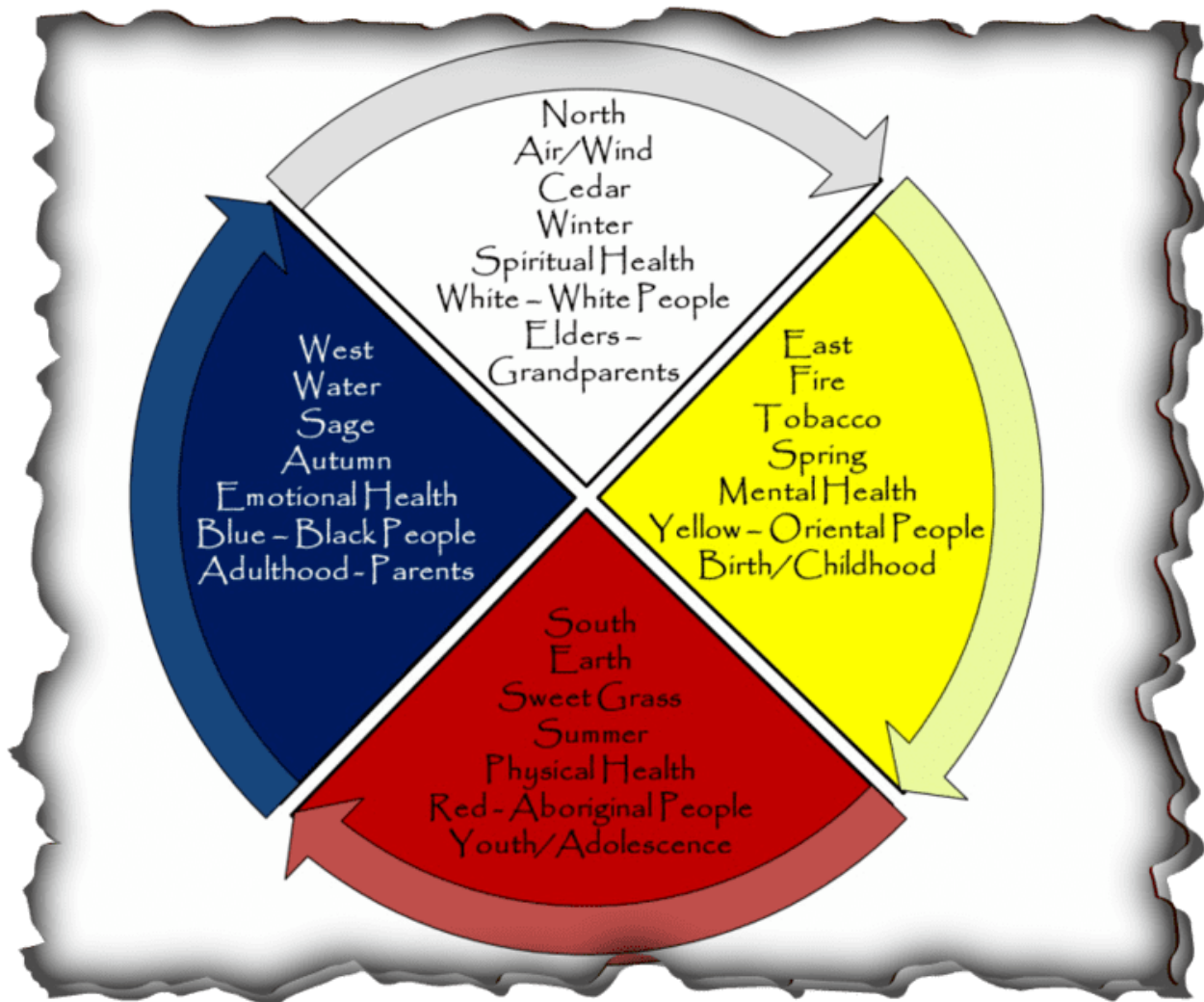
Turtle: Patience, Grounding, and Longevity

The Turtle is a symbol of patience, grounding, and longevity. Its slow and steady approach to life represents the importance of perseverance and steady progress. Also, it symbolizes the capacity to endure challenges and live a long life.

The turtle's grounded nature signifies stability and composure. It represents spiritual wisdom and steadfastness.

If the turtle is your totem, it may be a reminder to slow down, to be patient, and to focus on creating a stable foundation in your life. Consult the Medicine Wheel Totem Animals Guide.

<https://nativetribe.info/medicine-wheel-totem-animals-guide/>





Page 1: Cover Page Title: *My Medicine Wheel Journal* (Name) _____
(Grade) _____ (Date Started) _____

Page 2: What is the Medicine Wheel? The Medicine Wheel is a special circle used by many Indigenous peoples to understand the world. It teaches us about balance, health, and how everything is connected.

Draw or paste a picture of a Medicine Wheel here:

[Space for drawing]

Page 3: The Four Directions Label the four directions on the wheel:

- North (White)
- East (Yellow)
- South (Red)
- West (Black)

Draw arrows pointing to each direction on your wheel.

[Blank wheel template for labeling]

Page 4: The Four Aspects of Self Each direction also teaches us about ourselves:

- North: Mental
- East: Spiritual
- South: Emotional
- West: Physical

Draw or write about how you take care of each part of yourself.

[Four boxes for drawing or writing]

Page 5: Sacred Medicines Different medicines help us heal and stay balanced:

- Tobacco (East)
- Cedar (South)
- Sage (West)
- Sweetgrass (North)

Can you draw or find pictures of these medicines?

[Space for drawings or gluing images]

Page 6: Animal Symbols Some animals are connected to the directions:

- East: Eagle
- South: Wolf
- West: Buffalo
- North: Bear

Which animal do you feel most connected to and why?

[Writing prompt and space for drawing animal]

Page 7: My Wheel of Balance Think about your day or week:

- Did you do something for your body?
- Did you think or learn something new?
- Did you feel something strongly?
- Did you have quiet or prayer time?

Color in the parts of the wheel that you used this week.

[Blank color wheel for student reflection]

Page 8: Reflection What did you learn from the Medicine Wheel? How can you use the Medicine Wheel in your life?

[Writing space for reflection]

Back Cover Draw your own personal symbol of balance and healing:

[Blank space for creative expression]

Page 1: Cover Page Title: *My Medicine Wheel Journal* (Name) _____
(Grade) _____ (Date Started) _____

Page 2: What is the Medicine Wheel? The Medicine Wheel is a special circle used by many Indigenous peoples to understand the world. It teaches us about balance, health, and how everything is connected.

Draw or paste a picture of a Medicine Wheel here:

[Space for drawing]

Page 3: The Four Directions Label the four directions on the wheel:

- North (White)
- East (Yellow)
- South (Red)
- West (Black)

Draw arrows pointing to each direction on your wheel.

[Blank wheel template for labeling]

Page 4: Animal Symbols of the Medicine Wheel Each direction of the Medicine Wheel is connected to an animal. These animals are important in many Indigenous teachings:

- **North** – Grizzly Bear: represents strength and introspection
- **East** – Eagle: represents vision and spirituality
- **South** – Wolf: represents learning and relationships
- **West** – Buffalo: represents respect and abundance

Draw each animal in the correct direction on the Medicine Wheel.

[Blank wheel with labeled quadrants for student drawings]

Page 5: Learning from the Animals Think about what each animal can teach us. Write or draw your ideas below:

- What does the Eagle help us see?
- How does the Bear give us strength?
- Why is the Wolf a good teacher?
- How does the Buffalo show respect?

[Four boxes for writing or drawing about each animal]

Page 6: My Animal Connection Which animal do you feel most connected to and why? What lesson can that animal teach you?

[Writing prompt and space for drawing the animal]

Page 7: My Wheel of Balance Think about your day or week:

- Did you show strength like the Bear?
- Did you look closely or dream like the Eagle?
- Did you learn or help a friend like the Wolf?
- Did you share or give thanks like the Buffalo?

Color in the parts of the wheel that you lived this week.

[Blank color wheel for student reflection]

Page 8: Reflection What did you learn from the Medicine Wheel animals? How can you use what they teach in your life?

[Writing space for reflection]

Back Cover Draw your own personal symbol of balance, using what you learned from the animals:

[Blank space for creative expression]

Lesson Plan: Animals of the Medicine Wheel (Grade 3)

Grade Level: Grade 3

Time Needed: 45–60 minutes

Big Ideas (BC Curriculum):

- Stories and traditions help us understand ourselves and connect with others.
- Indigenous knowledge is passed through oral history, traditions, and collective memory.

First Peoples Principles of Learning:

- Learning is holistic, reflexive, reflective, experiential, and relational.
- Learning involves generational roles and responsibilities.
- Learning involves patience and time.

Learning Objectives: Students will:

- Learn about four animals of the Medicine Wheel (Grizzly Bear, Eagle, Buffalo, and Wolf).
- Understand the symbolic meanings of these animals and how they relate to different directions.
- Reflect on how these animals can teach us important life lessons.
- Practice respectful learning of Indigenous knowledge through stories, drawing, and discussion.

Materials:

- Large visual of the Medicine Wheel (with animals in each quadrant)
 - Printable student journals or drawing pages (e.g., Medicine Wheel templates)
 - Crayons/markers
 - Animal fact cards or images
 - Picture books or short videos introducing Indigenous animal teachings
 - Small talking stick or sharing item (for circle discussion)
-

Lesson Steps:

1. Welcome Circle (5–10 min)

- Begin with a land acknowledgment.
- Sit in a circle and introduce the Medicine Wheel as a way of learning about balance and connection.
- Ask: "What do we know about animals that help people?"

2. Introduction to the Medicine Wheel Animals (10–15 min)

- Present the Medicine Wheel with the four animals:
 - **North (White): Grizzly Bear** – strength, courage, introspection
 - **East (Yellow): Eagle** – vision, spirituality, guidance
 - **South (Red): Wolf** – learning, relationships, guardianship
 - **West (Black): Buffalo** – respect, sharing, gratitude
- Show images or short video clips of each animal.
- Discuss how each animal represents important values.

3. Storytime or Video (10–15 min)

- Read a picture book or show a video about one or more of the animals and their traditional teachings.
- Example: A story of the Eagle and its ability to see far or the Bear's strength during hibernation.

Storytime or Video (10–15 min)

- Read a picture book or show a video about one or more of the animals and their traditional teachings.
- Suggested Book: *"The Song Within My Heart"* by David Bouchard — a story that includes teachings about the drum and the connection to nature and animals.
- Suggested Video: A short clip from *"Four Sacred Medicines"* by Elder Mary Wilson or a video from your local Indigenous Education team, if available.
- Example: A story of the Eagle and its ability to see far or the Bear's strength during hibernation.

4. Hands-On Journal Activity (10–15 min)

- Provide each student with a Medicine Wheel template.
- Guide students to draw the four animals in their respective directions.
- Invite them to write or draw what each animal teaches us.

5. Sharing Circle (5–10 min)

- Invite students to share which animal they feel connected to and why.
- Use a talking stick or object to ensure respectful listening.

Assessment:

- Observe student participation and engagement in circle discussions.
- Review completed Medicine Wheel drawings and journal responses for understanding.

Extensions:

- Create a class "Animal Wheel" with everyone's chosen animal.
- Learn a song or drumming rhythm associated with one of the animals.
- Invite an Indigenous Knowledge Keeper or Elder to speak about animal teachings.

+++++

Printable Posters: Medicine Wheel Animals & Their Teachings

Grizzly Bear

Direction: North (White)

Represents: Strength, Courage, Introspection

Teaches Us:

- How to look within ourselves
 - Stay strong during challenges
 - Protect ourselves and others
- Symbol:** Hibernate for reflection and renewal
-

Eagle

Direction: East (Yellow)

Represents: Vision, Spirituality, Guidance

Teaches Us:

- How to see the big picture
 - Connect with our spirit
 - Rise above difficulties
- Symbol:** Flies highest and closest to the Creator
-

Wolf

Direction: South (Red)

Represents: Learning, Relationships, Guardianship

Teaches Us:

- How to learn from others
 - Live in harmony
 - Protect our communities
- Symbol:** Loyal pack member and teacher
-

Buffalo

Direction: West (Black)

Represents: Respect, Sharing, Gratitude

Teaches Us:

- Be generous and humbl

- Honor what we are given
 - Share with others
- Symbol:** Provider of food, clothing, and shelter for many
-

These posters can be printed and displayed around the classroom or included in student reflection journals.

Lesson Plan: Elements of the Medicine Wheel (Grade 4)

Grade Level: Grade 4

Time Needed: 60 minutes

Big Ideas (BC Curriculum):

- People's beliefs and values are shaped by their experiences and cultures.
- Interactions between people and the environment shape our world.
- Indigenous knowledge is passed down through oral history, stories, and traditions.

First Peoples Principles of Learning:

- Learning is holistic, reflexive, reflective, experiential, and relational.
- Learning is embedded in memory, history, and story.
- Learning involves recognizing the consequences of one's actions.
- Learning requires exploration of one's identity.

Learning Objectives: Students will:

- Identify the four elements represented in the Medicine Wheel (Air, Earth, Fire, Water).
- Understand the symbolism and teachings connected to each element.
- Recognize the traditional directional and color associations with each element.
- Reflect on their own connection to nature and the elements.

Materials:

- Large Medicine Wheel visual (with labeled elements)
- Printable Medicine Wheel templates (element version)
- Colored pencils/crayons (white, yellow, red, black)
- Storybook or video introducing the elements and the Medicine Wheel
- Access to nature (if possible, short outdoor walk or observation)
- Chart paper and markers for group discussion

Lesson Steps:

1. Introduction & Circle Discussion (10–15 min)

- Begin with a land acknowledgment.
- Sit in a circle and ask students: “What do you know about the four elements?”
- Introduce the Medicine Wheel as a way Indigenous Peoples connect to the natural world and find balance.
- Briefly explain the elements:
 - **Air (North - White):** breath, communication, mind
 - **Earth (East - Yellow):** growth, grounding, body
 - **Fire (South - Red):** passion, energy, spirit
 - **Water (West - Black):** emotion, intuition, heart

2. Story or Video (10–15 min)

- Share a story or video (e.g., local Elder’s teaching or a book like *“The Four Sacred Elements”*).
- Encourage students to listen for connections between the elements and themselves or the land.

3. Guided Group Discussion (10 min)

- Create a class chart for each element.
- Ask: What does fire feel like? What does water teach us? How do we experience air? What grows in the earth?
- Record student responses under each element.

4. Hands-On Activity (15–20 min)

- Distribute blank Medicine Wheel templates.
- Guide students to label each quadrant with the correct element, direction, and color:
 - North – Air – White
 - East – Earth – Yellow
 - South – Fire – Red
 - West – Water – Black
- Students draw or write about what each element means to them personally (e.g., “Water reminds me of swimming in the lake with my family.”)

5. Optional Outdoor Connection (if time & weather permit)

- Go on a short nature walk.
- Ask students to notice where they feel the elements around them (wind on their face, sun on skin, trees in soil, puddles or clouds).

6. Reflection & Sharing Circle (10 min)

- Return to the circle and invite students to share one element they feel most connected to and why.
 - Emphasize listening, respect, and gratitude.
-

Assessment:

- Participation in discussion and circle.
- Completed Medicine Wheel element worksheet (accuracy and personal reflection).
- Observation of thoughtful sharing and respectful listening.

Extensions:

- Create class mural with four quadrants representing each element and student contributions.
 - Explore how different cultures use the elements in ceremonies or stories.
 - Invite a local Elder or Knowledge Keeper to speak about the significance of the elements in their teachings.
-

Stages of Life on the Medicine Wheel

Grade Level: 5

Duration: 60 minutes

Subjects: Social Studies, Health & Career Education, Art

Location: Classroom & (optional) Outdoors

Big Ideas (BC Curriculum):

- Understanding the past helps us make sense of the present.
 - Our beliefs, values, and connections to others help shape who we are.
 - Indigenous knowledge is passed down through oral history, stories, and traditions.
-

First Peoples Principles of Learning:

- Learning is holistic, reflexive, reflective, experiential, and relational.
- Learning involves recognizing the consequences of one's actions.

- Learning is embedded in memory, history, and story.
 - Learning involves exploration of one's identity.
-

Learning Objectives:

Students will:

- Identify the four stages of life represented in the Medicine Wheel.
 - Understand the meanings and responsibilities associated with each life stage.
 - Recognize the directional, color, and seasonal associations of each stage.
 - Reflect on their own life stage and explore how teachings relate to personal growth.
 - Respectfully engage with Indigenous knowledge through story, discussion, and creative work.
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Materials:

- Large visual of the Medicine Wheel showing stages of life
 - Printable Medicine Wheel templates (with life stage quadrants)
 - Blank Medicine Wheel templates
 - Crayons or colored pencils (white, yellow, red, black)
 - Age-appropriate story, video, or Elder recording about life stages
 - Reflection journals or writing paper
 - Chart paper and markers
 - Sharing item or small talking stick (optional)
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Lesson Activities:

1. Introduction & Circle Discussion (10–15 min)

- Begin with a land acknowledgment.
 - Ask: *“What do you know about the stages of life? What do we learn at different times in our life?”*
 - Introduce the Medicine Wheel as a guide for living and growth.
 - Briefly explain the four stages of life:
 - **East (Yellow) – Infancy:** New beginnings, curiosity, openness
 - **South (Red) – Youth:** Learning, identity, energy
 - **West (Black) – Adulthood:** Responsibility, reflection, care for others
 - **North (White) – Elder:** Wisdom, teaching, peace
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2. Story or Video (10–15 min)

- Share a story from a book or Elder teaching about growing through life stages.
 - Encourage students to listen for teachings from each stage and how they relate to the wheel.
 - Example book: *“The Four Seasons of Life”* (if available) or a local Indigenous voice via video.
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3. Guided Group Discussion (10 min)

- Create a class anchor chart divided into four quadrants: Infancy, Youth, Adulthood, Elder.
 - Ask: *“What do we learn as a baby? What are some things youth need to know? What does adulthood bring? Why are Elders important?”*
 - Write student ideas in each section.
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4. Hands-On Activity (15–20 min)

- Hand out the blank Medicine Wheel life stages templates.
 - Students color each quadrant and label:
 - **East – Infancy – Yellow**
 - **South – Youth – Red**
 - **West – Adulthood – Black**
 - **North – Elder – White**
 - Example: “As a youth, I’m learning who I am.”
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5. Optional Outdoor Reflection (if time & weather allow)

- Go outside and reflect quietly: *“What do you see or feel that reminds you of your stage in life?”*
 - Encourage drawing or journaling about the experience back inside.
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6. Sharing Circle & Reflection (10 min)

- Return to the circle and invite students to share one thing they wrote or drew.
- Emphasize respect, listening, and gratitude.
- Prompt: *“What stage are you in now? What do you think is important about it?”*

Assessment & Extension

Assessment:

- Observe participation during group discussions and reflections.
- Review completed Medicine Wheel templates for understanding and personal insight.
- Anecdotal notes on respectful listening and sharing.

Extensions:

- Invite a local Elder or Knowledge Keeper to speak about the teachings of life stages.
- Create a collaborative class wheel with student contributions in each quadrant.
- Compare with other cultural understandings of life stages and aging.

Resources:

- *Keepers of the Earth* – Michael J. Caduto & Joseph Bruchac
 - *Four Winds* – Mike Bowden
 - *Medicine Wheel Workbook* – Carrie Armstrong
 - *The Medicine Wheel: Stories of a Hoop* – (for older students)
 - Cultural Protocols Poster
 - Blank Medicine Wheel Template
 - Life Stages Poster (available on request)
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☒ If you want an image like the one you attached (a square, stylized Medicine Wheel with labels and icons), you should ask for something like this:

"Can you create a 768x768 pixel PNG image in the same style as the Medicine Wheel Elements poster (with the beige background, bold labels, simple icons, and plant decorations)?"

— Then tell me what **content** you want in each quadrant.

💡 **For example:**

If you're making one about life stages, you can say:

"Make a square Medicine Wheel poster (768x768, PNG) with:

- Top (North): Elder

- Right (East): Infancy
- Bottom (South): Youth
- Left (West): Adult

Use the same style as the 'Air/Earth/Elements' wheel with icons and earthy tones."

□ Bonus: If it's going on your website, add:

"Format it for use in a `<img src='...' style='...' >` tag on my website — just like the Fire/Water/Air example."

Sacred Medicines on the Medicine Wheel

Grade Level: 7

Duration: 1–2 class periods (60–90 mins total)

Subjects: Art Education, Social Studies, Health & Physical Education

Location: Classroom & Outdoors

Big Ideas (BC Curriculum):

- Learning about Indigenous perspectives helps us understand the importance of balance and respect in our lives and communities.
 - Indigenous knowledge systems provide holistic and meaningful approaches to health, culture, and well-being.
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First Peoples Principles of Learning:

- Learning is holistic, reflexive, reflective, experiential, and relational.
 - Learning involves generational roles and responsibilities.
 - Learning recognizes Indigenous knowledge systems and worldviews.
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Learning Objectives:

Students will:

- Identify the four sacred medicines: sage, sweetgrass, cedar, and tobacco.
 - Understand the traditional roles and teachings of each medicine.
 - Explore the connections between the sacred medicines and the four quadrants of the Medicine Wheel.
 - Reflect on how Indigenous teachings about wellness relate to their own health and identity.
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Materials:

- Visual of the Medicine Wheel with labeled directions, colors, and meanings
 - Printable visuals or real samples of sage, sweetgrass, cedar, and tobacco (if available)
 - Blank Medicine Wheel templates
 - Chart paper or whiteboard
 - Markers or colored pencils
 - Journals or reflection paper
 - Cultural Protocols Poster
 - Talking stick or similar item for circle time
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Lesson Activities:

1: Opening Circle / Introduction (10–15 min)

- Begin with a respectful land acknowledgment (invite students to create a personal version).
- Ask students: “What do you already know about sacred medicines?”
- Introduce the Medicine Wheel as a framework used by many Indigenous Nations for balance, healing, and understanding the world.
- Briefly review the quadrants: Spiritual (white/north), Mental (yellow/east), Physical (red/south), Emotional (black/west).

2: Teachings of the Sacred Medicines (20–30 min)

- Introduce the four sacred medicines:
 - **Sage** (often linked with cleansing and wisdom)
 - **Sweetgrass** (used in ceremony, symbolizes kindness and connection)
 - **Cedar** (used in protection, healing, and purification)
 - **Tobacco** (used in offerings and prayer, for respect and communication)
- Explain that each medicine has unique teachings and can be connected to one or more quadrants of the Medicine Wheel.
- Highlight that these medicines are used respectfully in ceremony and that traditions may differ by community.
- Show real samples if appropriate and permitted.

3: Personal Reflection Activity (20–30 min)

- On chart paper, brainstorm how each medicine might support one's well-being in the physical, mental, emotional, and spiritual aspects.
- Distribute the blank Medicine Wheel template.
- Students draw or write one idea in each quadrant connecting it to one of the sacred medicines (e.g., "Sweetgrass helps my emotions because its smell makes me feel calm.")
- Invite optional sharing in pairs, small groups, or a talking circle.

4: Closing Discussion (10 min)

- Ask students: What medicine or quadrant did you feel most connected to today? Why?
- How do you think using these teachings could help a community?
- Option: Write a short reflection paragraph.

Assessment & Extension

Assessment:

- Active participation in discussion and circle time
- Thoughtful completion of Medicine Wheel reflection worksheet
- Optional exit slip: "One thing I learned about sacred medicines is..."

Extensions:

- Invite an Elder or Knowledge Keeper to share teachings (with protocols)
- Use art to create a collective Medicine Wheel poster with visuals of the medicines
- Explore how the medicines relate to emotional regulation, mental focus, physical practices, and spiritual reflection

Resources:

- *The Sacred Tree* – by Four Worlds Development Project
- *Medicine Wheel Workbook* – by Carrie Armstrong, Kelly Armstrong, River Armstrong
- *Clarity Posters* – Emotional, Physical, Mental, Spiritual
- *Blank Medicine Wheel Template*
- *Cultural Protocols Poster*